



Ruderman Chabad Inclusion Initiative

Practical Ideas for Inclusive Bar and Bat Mitzvahs

*Some Materials Adapted from Jewish Community Guide to Inclusion of People with Disabilities
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Introduction to Inclusion

- 20% of all people have some kind of disability including those that are not apparent such as mental health conditions, severe allergies, learning disabilities, etc.
- This means there likely isn't one family without a member or a close friend who has a disability. Disability in some way impacts each of us.
- If you cannot accommodate even one member of a family, the entire family may go elsewhere.

Inclusion is NOT

- Creating special programs for people with disabilities.
- Showing compassion, pity or patronization.
- Making people with disabilities feel special or see them as suffering or needy.
- Making caregivers into heroes.
- Only about building ramps, accessible restrooms and parking spots.

Inclusion IS

- Identifying and eliminating the barriers to inclusion so that ALL people, including those who have disabilities and require accommodations, can participate in your REGULAR activities.
- Ensuring that nobody is excluded in any way because of a disability.
- Not labeling or defining a person by his or her disability. Rather, seeing the person first, regardless of ability or disability. That is why so much emphasis is placed on using Person First language. (A person with a disability, not a disabled person).
- Recognizing that we all have different needs and we all may need some type of accommodation in order to fully participate.
- Asking if the individual needs an accommodation, and if he or she tells you they do, offering to coordinate and provide what is needed.
- As spiritual leaders, supporting each person so that he or she can fulfill the *mitzvot*.
- Eliminating barriers that may prevent someone from participating as they wish in any or all communal activities.

Benefits of Inclusion:

- Inclusion practices the value of *v'ahavta lereiacha kamocha*, to love your fellow Jew like yourself.
- Motivate community members to build an inclusive community.
- Demonstrate to donors that your organization has a vision and is proactively creating inclusive communities by promoting inclusion awareness.

Typical Barriers to Inclusion

Attitudinal barriers are important to overcome because they require a shift in thinking about people with disabilities. The barriers of attitude exist when someone who has a disability feels invisible or unwelcome. Attitudinal barriers are the most difficult to see. When we look through a person and do not engage with them, we are not seeing their humanity—we are seeing their disability.

Barriers of attitude are present when we say “this is how we’ve always done it” or when we close our eyes to the needs of others because we do not have enough information to do what we think is right. Our beliefs about people with disabilities often cause us to feel pity or fear, or embrace stereotypes about the potential of people with disabilities.

Physical or architectural barriers. Most of us are familiar with barriers to physical access. Lack of access to the building, the *bima*, classrooms, restrooms and parking are often cited as barriers to participation. If a person cannot access the building or the programs because of barriers such as stairs, lack of space for wheelchairs and walkers, or safety devices such as grab bars in restrooms, then those who use mobility devices are often left out.

Communication barriers include a range of ways that people access information and participate. Receptive language communication barriers occur when a person is deaf or hard of hearing. If someone is hard of hearing, do they have access to assistive listening devices? Do you have sign language interpreters for those individuals who communicate using American Sign Language (ASL)? Is there seating near the front so that people can see the sign language interpreter or the speaker?

Communication barriers also exist when someone has difficulty responding. Examples include dyslexia (a reading disorder), dysgraphia (a writing disorder) aphasia (loss of ability to speak or understand speech), stroke or cerebral palsy.

Much of our communication is facilitated through gestures, facial expressions and other non-verbal cues. Some people have difficulty reading those non-verbal forms of communication and may not understand the nuances conveyed.

Visual barriers include the lack of large print prayer books, school materials and bulletins. Alternate means of accommodating someone who has vision challenges might include having large print prayer books readily available. Have prayer books and other materials in Braille format available when someone makes that request.

Why *Bar* and *Bat Mitzvahs* Are Important

- The *Bar* and *Bat Mitzvah* are milestones marking a child's entrance into responsible Judaism.
- Every young adult has the responsibility to perform *mitzvot*.
- *Bar* and *Bat Mitzvah* offers a meaningful experience for the young adult, the family and the congregation celebrating this important life cycle event.
- An opportunity for a young Jewish person to learn and study about his or her Jewish heritage.
- An occasion for a young Jewish person to use his or her unique gifts and strengths to celebrate becoming an adult member of the community.

Keys to Success: Adapting *Bar* and *Bat Mitzvah* Celebrations for Children with Disabilities

- Determine the child's strengths as well as interests.
- Focus on what the child can do.
- Find appropriate opportunities in which the child can shine.
- Find out what motivates the child so that the tutor, rabbi, and family can identify strategies that work for each individual child.
- Be creative in using a child's interests to highlight his or her participation.
- Be flexible in what is required based on the individual child. There is no one size fits all approach.
- The *brachot* are the most important part of the *aliyah* experience. If a child has difficulty reading the *Torah* they can still go to up to recite the *brachot* and stay for the duration of the *aliyah*.

Although there is no *Halachic* obligation to celebrate a *Bar* or *Bat Mitzvah* in any specific way other than the coming of age or putting on *tefillin* (for boys), many synagogues are committed to including all children in a *Bar* and *Bat Mitzvah* program.

Celebrating a *Bar* or *Bat Mitzvah* has much to do with preparation and communication between rabbis, parents, teachers and students. The process itself can be enormously enriching for everyone involved. There is something so rewarding and special when a child with a disability crosses the threshold into adult Judaism in his or her own unique way.

Steps to Successful Partnerships

Many parents are concerned about how their child will be able to learn their *Torah* and *Haftarah* portions and lead or participate in services before the entire congregation. Some parents may assume that because their child has a disability, they may not be welcome to participate. Establishing good communication with parents sets a positive foundation.

Meet with the parents and the child to decide what the most appropriate setting for the celebration is: *Shabbat* morning service, *Rosh Chodesh*, a weekday *minyan* or *Havdala* service.

Children with disabilities should be included when choosing dates and scheduling the ceremonies. For children who can read, discuss an appropriate length of the *Torah* and/or *Haftarah* portions for them to read. For those who do not read talk about the meaning of the text. You may find that there are parts of the *Torah* portion that are especially meaningful to the child. It is important to be flexible. No one can predict how well the child will do until they begin studying.

Many children are nervous or intimidated when they begin their individual tutoring. Children with disabilities have unique ways of understanding this important milestone in their lives, and this can be a time of incredible growth and development for them.

A Word About Assistive Technology

There are numerous apps that can help some children with disabilities with learning *brachas* and the *parsha*. These can be found at the iTunes store or the Google App store.

“The Best Day of My Life”

The *Bar* or *Bat Mitzvah* ceremonies of children who have disabilities are always very moving and emotional experiences for the child’s parents and the congregation. This significant life cycle event is one that parents dream about from the moment their child is born. When the child is diagnosed with a disability, the dream of a *Bar* or *Bat Mitzvah* may become elusive as parents begin their unique journey. As their child stands at the *bima* participating in the ceremony, only the parents know the route that it took to make it to this day. They feel pride in their child, pride in their own perseverance and a sense of wholeness that their child has reached the age of Jewish adulthood.

When Eli’s tutor began working with him, he quickly noticed that Eli had a strong rote memory for the material, and his auditory learning skills were very well-developed. Eli is legally blind and his glasses had thick lenses.

Eli has a wonderful musical memory which assisted his learning to read from the Torah. He learned the trope quickly. He learned his *brachot* using his remarkable memory for music. New information about Eli came to light. He had a fine tuned musical ability. He could listen to music once and then play it on the piano.

One thing led to another. Eli had a wonderful *Bar Mitzvah*, and his coming of age ceremony was celebrated by the entire congregation. After his *Bar Mitzvah*, Eli continued at Hebrew school, taking an elective class in which students learned liturgical music to sing at services. Recognizing Eli’s musical talents during his *Bar Mitzvah* preparation smoothed the way for others in the congregation to encourage Eli’s abilities.

Eli’s tutor saw him six months after his *Bar Mitzvah*. During their conversation, he excitedly said, “My *Bar Mitzvah* was the best day of my life!”

The support and love he continues to receive from his synagogue community have guided him to explore his passion for music and may one day even provide a career for him. It was the best day in Eli’s life; indeed, it was a milestone in the life of his congregation, too.

Practical Accommodations and Modifications

There are many types of accommodations that you can implement. Being creative can help you arrive at solutions that are appropriate. The important thing is to remember that a *Bar* or *Bat Mitzvah* child who has a disability will come to this important passage and find personal meaning in it. We must create opportunities that nurture the growth and development of our children.

Putting on Tefillin

The mitzvah of putting on *tefillin* is more important than an *Aliyah*. This is something tangible that they can learn, and do for the rest of their lives.

Many Shluchim have run *tefillin* workshops showing their students what is inside the *tefillin*. This is an opportunity for the child to become familiar and physically comfortable with the materials. Children can explore the *tefillin* a few times before actually wearing them. Parents can participate in this mitzvah with their child, creating a wonderful bond. You can encourage parents to come to shul on Sunday morning and join all the others wearing *tefillin*.

Some children with disabilities may need more practice with *tefillin*. These tips can help:

- Plan for additional exposure and practice before the child is fully comfortable wearing *tefillin*.
- Congratulate the child on every small step they take toward the goal of wearing *tefillin* and find opportunities for them to shine.
- Plan a *hanachat tefillin* for the congregation as another more low key celebration.
- Practice is important even after the *bar mitzvah*.
- A child may need to start with just putting the *tefillin* against their skin without actually being wrapped tightly and build up to wrapping properly over time.
- Try to ensure that the *tefillin* are kept at room temperature as some people are sensitive to slight to extreme variations of hot or cold.
- Practice the arm strapping with an old pair of *tefillin* rather than using play *tefillin* because the straps will have a different feel. Some people, however, may prefer to practice with play *tefillin*.
- A calming technique for some children who may have a tendency toward sensory overstimulation is brushing. This can also help prepare them for a new sensory experience. Be sure to consult with the family and, if they allow, the child's therapist in advance.
- Consult a *rav* if someone may be more comfortable with just arm or head because of sensory input. Others may be fine with arm and head but the 7 straps around the arm may be overwhelming. There may be flexibility here *halachically* so please inquire. Also, if someone is missing an arm they can say *bracha* just on head *tefillin*.

Does not read Hebrew

- Transliterate the Hebrew.
- Record the *t'filot* and *haftara* portions to help the child memorize them.
- Child can carry the *Sefer Torah* to the *bima* and back to the *Aron*.

- Child can stand next to the *ba'al koreh* or his father while Dad reads the *Torah*.
- Child can remove the mantle and/or dress the *Torah*.

Does not verbalize

- Sign language or low-tech augmentative communication devices can be used so the child can express himself or herself.
- The child can paint a picture in lieu of giving a verbal *d'var Torah* to share with the congregation.
- The parent can read from the *Torah* while the child stands next to him and/or holds the *yad* or *atzei chaim*.
- Have a Thursday night *challa* bake highlighting the *mitzvah* of *Hafrashat Challa*.

Does not sit still

- Announce that the child may express himself or herself in his or her unique way.
- Seating the child next to a trusted adult or the rabbi may relax the child and also shows his or her valued place in the congregation.
- Have a trusted adult or aide that the child knows well who can take him out of the service if needed.
- Plan for breaks if you think that the *Bar Mitzvah* boy doesn't need to be in the sanctuary the whole time.

Does not walk or stand

- Is the *bima* accessible to a child who uses a wheelchair? Can it be lowered or can you use an alternative reading table that is lower?
- Think about placing the *bima* on the main level for access by anyone using a wheelchair or walker, including older family members.

Is uncomfortable speaking

- Consider alternative ways to give a *drasha*, such as creating an art project or if during the week, a PowerPoint presentation about the *parsha*. Have a sibling or other family member read the *parsha* while the child stands nearby.
- Have the child write the *parsha* article for the shul bulletin. Have a family member read it aloud at the celebration.
- Have the child hold the candle at *Havdalla* ceremony.
- For a child who has a speech impairment ensure that a copy of his speech is placed at each seat so congregants can follow along
- Another way to give the *d'var Torah* is to create a story board of photographs that family and friends develop and post on a foam core board. The child can practice beforehand, answering a set of questions about the *parshah* or about becoming a *Bar* or *Bat Mitzvah*.

Is Deaf and uses sign language

- The child can learn to sign the *parsha* in American Sign Language while someone else reads it.
- Have the child give the *drash* in sign language while an interpreter translates it.

Feels nervous or anxious

- Hold the *Bar* or *Bat mitzvah* ceremony at a time other than on *Shabbat* morning so the family can limit the number of people to those the child knows.
- Often if a child can practice in the *shul* several times prior to the service it will help him or her feel more comfortable as they are familiar with the space.
- Be sure that a trusted adult is with the child at all times such as the child's tutor.

Be Creative!

Depending on the time of year the *bar* or *bat mitva* occurs

- Create a program where the child could use his or her talents to shine.
- It could be a *megilla* reading, a *mitzvah/chesed* project, such as making fruit baskets at *Purim* for people who live in homeless shelters.
- The child could create a Passover *haggada*.
- Have friends join together to bake *matza*.
- Conduct a celebratory meal in the *shul sukka*.
- A Learn-a-Thon for *Shavuot*, or any other time, can be organized in the child's merit.
- Record the child practicing the Torah reading to show him on the day of his *bar mitzvah* to help build confidence and give him cues, if needed.
- If the *bar* or *bat mitzvah* is not on *Shabbat*, take photos and videos of the child. The day may be overwhelming, and having these precious reminders will help the child as well as the family relish in the moment for years to come.

Please contact info@RCII.org if you have any further questions or need information.

Teaching Tips

The parents and the teacher should meet one-on-one to discuss the child's strengths and abilities as well as challenges. Sharing the Individual Education Program (IEP) with the teacher can provide strategies to teach the child.

Teach students to their abilities and strengths as learners.

- Record the materials, including *b'rachot* and the *parsha* and *haftara*. Save each *b'racha* and each verse as individual mp3 files which makes it easier to organize when the student downloads and saves to electronic devices.
- For students who have difficulty reading Hebrew, transliterate the materials.
- Let the young man open and unroll the *Torah* to become familiar with it, show him the *parsha*; let him try reading from the scroll early in the process.
- Enlarge the *tikkun* pages for all students.
- Let the student use a *yad* to point to the words he is reading during lessons.
- Discuss the *parsha* with the student and help him or her understand the *p'shat*.
- Discuss the *parsha* at each lesson. This takes away some of the stress by focusing away from the ability.
- Spend time at the *bima* and explain the items found there.
- Occasionally invite parents to lessons so they can observe how their child is progressing.

- Use visual cues to teach the prayers and the order of the service. Some students with disabilities work much better with an organized structure or using visual cues.
- Create a sequence story of what will happen on the day of *the bar* or *bat mitzvah*.
- Work closely with the family keeping them informed about the child's progress and the accommodations to learning. Discuss any challenges you encounter with the family in a timely manner.
- Help the child anticipate anything that might contribute to feeling anxious.
- Make sure that the child knows and is comfortable with those who will be at the *bima*.
- Consider having the teacher serve as *gabbai*. This is also especially helpful if a child has processing difficulties and needs to have someone chant quietly along with them in order to remember.
- Recognize a student's achievements at each lesson. Try stickers or stars. For some children, a good motivator is something that they love, like baseball cards. Talk with the parents about providing a supply.
- Prepare the student for this moment by practicing the entire service several times before the actual ceremony.

We have learned that in order to open our doors to celebrating *Bar or Bat mitzvah* with children who have disabilities, sometimes we need accommodations and modifications, and other times we do not. It may very well be that in the beginning of the process, you may not know exactly what the service will be like but you will journey along with the child and parents to make this important discovery. Remember the words of Eli: "My *Bar Mitzvah* was the best day of my life!"

Bar mitzvah homework assignment for a child who can read Hebrew

Student: Eli

Week of January 15

Date	Parent Initials	<i>Torah</i> 15 minutes	<i>Haftara</i> ____ minutes	<i>T'fila</i> 10 minutes
		Learn verse 10 on trope side, listen to recording. (10 minutes) Review verses 1-9 on <i>Torah</i> side (5 minutes)	We are scheduled to start your <i>Haftarah</i> portion the first week of March	Study <i>Haftara b'racha</i> before the reading (5 minutes) Review <i>Torah b'rachot</i> before and after the reading (5 minutes)
		Same		Same
		Same		Same
		Same		Same
		Same		Same
		Move verse 10 to <i>Torah</i> , practice (10 minutes) Review 1-9 on <i>Torah</i> side (10 minutes)		Same
<i>Shabbat</i>				

Bar mitzvah homework assignment for a child who can read Hebrew

Student _____		Week of _____		
Day	Parent Initial	<i>Torah</i> ____ minutes	<i>Haftara</i> ____ minutes	<i>T'fila</i> ____ minutes